

are showing their invigorating effects upon the men daily, almost hourly."

However this spring was inadequate for the routine camp life of a thousand man regiment and their compliment of horses, mules and other livestock. The men of the fort made daily trips to the Salt and Ohio Rivers to fill their needs for additional water.

Well, we hope you have enjoyed our tour of the fort. For additional reading we recommend that you pick up a copy of Richard Briggs book "West Point and the Civil War". Available at shops and businesses in the town of West Point.

Volunteers Wanted

The Fort Duffield Heritage Committee is a support organization for this site. It's members assist with fund-raising, special events, tours of this site, and work on developing and maintaining this historic fort. Their volunteer help is essential to the site's success as a place where students, historians, tourists, and local citizens can learn about the unique history that Fort Duffield and West Point have to offer.

If you would like to help volunteer your time to Fort Duffield please contact:

City Hall located at 6th and Elm Street
or call 922-4260

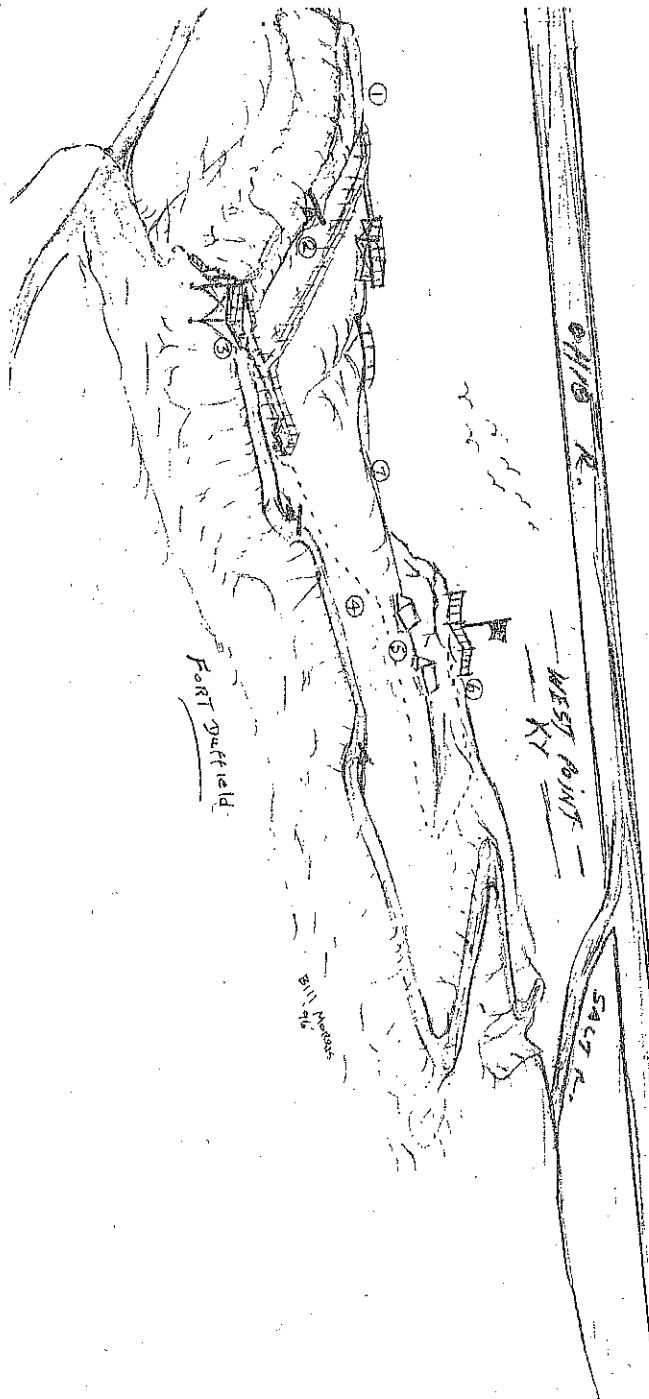
Donations to the Fort Duffield restoration may be made to:

Ft. Duffield Heritage Committee
1109 Elm Street

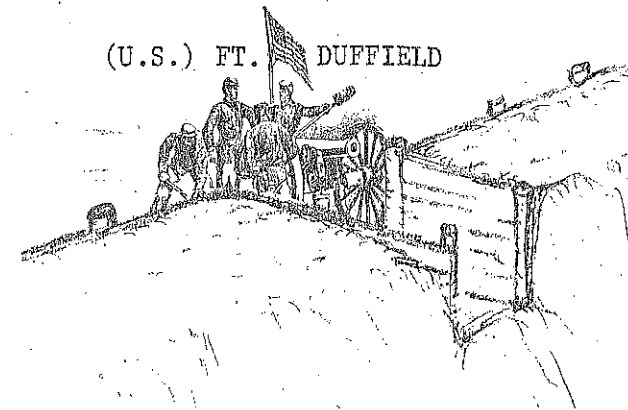
West Point, Ky. 40177

All donations are tax deductible and appreciated.

Brochure funded by the Kentucky Humanities Council



Walking Tour of Fort Duffield West Point, Kentucky



Please take a brochure and take the self guided tour through Fort Duffield. Follow the numbers along the trail and read the adjoining text.

Welcome to Fort Duffield

As you follow the numbers, please read the adjoining text in the brochure to give you a better understanding of the history behind the fort and the town below.

1. A large timbered gate was located both here and at the other end of this 1000 foot long earthen fort. Both gate areas hugged the cliff so as to allow maximum protection for the defenders. The fort was so secure that when the request was made for locks for the gates the quartermaster sent two toy locks as a joke. Capt. Charles Victor DeLand, Commander of Co. C, 9th Michigan Infantry, stated in a letter home that they felt "as secure as a nest of young eagles in our new fort."

2. At least one cannon would have to be positioned behind each of the ten angles of the fort wall for all around covering fire in the direction of the many back roads to the south of the fort. At first the 9th Michigan Infantry manned their own cannons; but by March of 1862, Capt. Charles H. Lanphere's Coldwater (Michigan) artillery battery had arrived to garrison the fort. The most common cannon used at the fort was the 6 pound smooth bore.

3. From this observation point one can see how impregnable the fort must have been. The forest has reclaimed the area but at the time there was at least a one mile clearing in every direction. With such a commanding view and garrisoned with a thousand men, it is no wonder that the massive fortifications was never attacked.

Take notice of the walls in both directions. According to a letter by Charles V. DeLand, Commander of Co. C, 9th Michigan Infantry, the distance from the top of the wall to the bottom of the ditch was 17 ft.. The top of the wall was 9 ft. wide. Time has eroded the walls to today's present height and thickness.

4. Civil War fortifications were precisely designed. Every angle, every mound of earth, and every slope you see here in Fort Duffield had a specific purpose. The ten angles of the fort were designed to allow infantry and artillery to sweep every inch of ground in front of the fort. There were no "dead spaces" where an attacking foe could take refuge. As Capt. DeLand wrote, "every gun in the Fort will sweep the turnpikes and rivers with shot and shell for three miles."

5. This central area of the fort, which contains the bulk of the ruins, was the command center of the fort. From an elevated vantage point at this location, a commander would have a full view of the interior of the fort and the surrounding outposts on the adjoining hills.

The men were ordered to "hut themselves by their own labor." The depressions you see before you were leveled out of the side of the hill to provide a base for simple log cabins with stone fireplaces. Several rows of these depressions can still be seen on this downhill slope.

By December 23, 1861, Col. Duffield wrote to General Robertson, "I have...placed the entire command (a thousand men) in log huts."

6. From this lookout, the troops that garrisoned Fort Duffield could see all the military activities that were taking place in the town of West Point below. Early in the war, West Point was the main

supply base for Gen. William Tecumseh Sherman's army which was then about 40 miles south astride the Louisville-Nashville Turnpike. West Point was a bee-hive of activities. By November of 1861, seven regiments of infantry and a cavalry regiment occupied the town and furnished support to the troops in the fort. A correspondent for a Detroit newspaper described the scene in the village as one of complete turmoil, with hundred upon hundreds of wagons being loaded with supplies from the steamboats for transfer to the Union Army to the south.

Three houses in West Point were commandeered for military hospitals where several hundred men were treated, and sixty-one died. These soldiers were buried on the hill to the south of the fort.

On the high hill on the Indiana side of the Ohio River, another small fort was built and occupied by Indiana troops and artillery. As you look at West Point below, Salt River joins the Ohio river directly in front of you. A pontoon bridge across the Salt River was built by the 9th Michigan. At one time gunboats patrolled the Ohio River with guns aimed at the turnpike.

7. THIS WATER IS UNTESTED BY TODAY'S STANDARDS PLEASE DO NOT DRINK. This spring was dug and blown out of the hillside by the soldiers of fort Duffield. Note the drill hole markings in the stone. A hand cut channel in the stone brings the overflow water from one basin to the next.

The spring provided fresh drinking water year round and would have proved invaluable to the men of the fort, especially if it had been brought under siege.

Captain DeLand of the 9th Michigan wrote on December 5th, 1861, "Our new camp upon the mountain is a paradise to what we have enjoyed for the past four weeks, and pure air and water